BUY BUSINESSES ON YOUR TERMS

From Target Search to Owner Conversations: Build Your Acquisition Pipeline with Confidence.



GODFRED OFOSU ASANTE

A guide to disciplined origination

A practical guide to LinkedIn Sales Navigator

For business buyers, acquisition entrepreneurs, corporate development teams and advisers who need a repeatable way to find companies and begin useful conversations with their owners.

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The focus is deal origination: research, qualification, outreach and the handover into a transaction process. Profile details and search signals require verification; they do not prove ownership, financial performance or willingness to transact. Fictional examples are identified. Features and subscription availability may change; official references appear at the back.

How to use this book

Read Chapters 1-6 to establish the mandate, research method and quality controls. Chapters 7-10 cover outreach, appointments and pipeline management. Chapter 11 addresses sell-side and merger work; Chapters 12-13 cover delivery and improvement. Use the worksheets to put the method into practice.

The methods draw on my lead generation and campaign operations work. Client-specific prices, guarantees and instructions are not general performance benchmarks.

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Introduction | A better beginning to the deal

A promising acquisition often begins quietly. An owner accepts an introduction. A conversation reveals a succession problem, a growth constraint or a wish to spend less time running the company. Nothing is signed. The business may never have been advertised for sale. But there is now a relationship worth developing.

Sales Navigator can help you find that starting point. It gives structure to company and people research, makes a large market easier to examine, and helps you keep track of organisations and individuals worth watching. The judgment remains yours: knowing what you want to buy, judging the evidence, approaching people with a credible reason and following through.

My work in lead generation, account management and operations has involved translating client requirements into research criteria, coordinating outreach and keeping campaign delivery organised. The recurring problems were rarely solved by sending more messages. They were solved by clarifying the target, checking the list, agreeing who should answer a difficult question and recording the next action properly.

That is the approach in this book. Start with a clear mandate. Research companies before deciding whom to contact. Check the first batch carefully. Be honest about your role. Treat a booked appointment as the start of qualification, then manage what happens after the call.

The same discipline helps a seller's adviser identify potential buyers and helps a corporate development team map merger partners. Their objectives differ, so their searches and messages must differ too. This guide keeps those distinctions visible rather than using one acquisition script for every situation.

You will find practical instructions, sample search strings, original message templates and working forms. Use the examples to understand the method, then adapt the criteria to your own mandate. A search that works for a regional engineering buyer may be unsuitable for a software investor. A founder's title may identify the right person, but it does not prove who owns the shares.

Build a pipeline you can explain: where a company came from, why it fits, what has been verified, who has been approached and what should happen next. That is a more useful asset than a long list of names.

CHAPTER 01

Write the mandate before the search

Know what you intend to own.

If every business looks attractive, your mandate needs work.

01

01 | Write the mandate before the search

Define the transaction you are trying to originate

Define the business you want before the market defines it for you. An acquisition mandate is a set of decisions. What sort of business are you seeking? Why should you be its next owner? What can you fund and operate? Where are you willing to invest time? If the answers are vague, every interesting company will appear to qualify.

Write a one-page brief before opening Sales Navigator. Specify the transaction objective, target market, business model, geography, size, ownership preferences and exclusions. Separate firm requirements from preferences. A regulated activity you cannot operate may be a hard exclusion. A slightly smaller headcount may be acceptable if the business has the right customers and management team.

Distinguish revenue, profit and transaction value. A company with £5 million of sales is not automatically a £5 million acquisition. LinkedIn headcount and revenue categories can help you organise research; neither substitutes for financial information obtained during a transaction process.

Match the brief to your role

Role	Research objective	First conversation
Business buyer	Find suitable acquisition targets	Establish interest and understand the owner
Sell-side adviser	Identify plausible buyers for a mandate	Confirm strategic fit and appetite discreetly
Merger or corporate development team	Map complementary organisations	Explore whether a strategic discussion is useful
Origination provider	Research and introduce prospects within an agreed scope	Qualify interest and hand over to the principal

Be precise about authority. A self-funded buyer should not imply an institutional fund mandate. An adviser should not imply a signed engagement if one does not exist. A research provider should not negotiate acquisition terms on behalf of a client without the relevant authority.

A worked acquisition brief

Fictional example: A UK buyer seeks an established facilities-services company with a regional customer base and repeat contracts. The initial research bands are 11-50 or 51-200 employees and a revenue indication of £2 million-£10 million where available. The buyer prefers an owner-led company with a manager who could support a transition. Pure recruitment agencies and newly formed businesses are excluded.

Those bands are starting assumptions. A subcontractor-heavy operator may have few listed employees yet substantial activity. A small company may be an attractive add-on. Record exceptions for review instead of forcing every firm into a platform category.

Translate the brief into research rules

For each requirement, state how it will be checked. Industry can be screened in Sales Navigator, then confirmed on the company website. Location may mean headquarters, operating territory or customer base; specify which. Ownership should be checked against suitable corporate records and clarified with the relevant person. Profitability and funding requirements belong in later qualification, with appropriate confidentiality arrangements.

Keep two columns: **evidence available now** and **questions for later**. This prevents public-data research from pretending to be due diligence. Finish the brief with the name of the person who can approve changes. A researcher should never quietly widen the mandate merely to produce a larger list.

CHAPTER 02

Build a credible profile and a workable setup

Earn the right to be taken seriously.

The owner has spent twenty years building the business. You can spend twenty minutes researching it.

02

02 | Build a credible profile and a workable setup

Give the owner a reason to take you seriously

Your profile is part of the approach. Before responding, an owner may inspect it. It should explain who you are, your role and the reason for the approach. Use a clear photograph, an accurate headline, a concise About section and experience that supports your proposition. Link to a professional website or a suitable company page if you have one.

A useful buyer headline might be: **Business buyer focused on UK facilities services | Operational transition and long-term ownership**. Use it only if it describes your actual activity. A sell-side adviser should state the advisory role. A searcher still raising capital should describe that position clearly rather than claim committed funds.

Your About section can cover the sectors you understand, the type of businesses you wish to discuss, your relevant background and how people can contact you. Keep it specific. Avoid claims such as guaranteed funding, guaranteed exits or a record of completed acquisitions you cannot substantiate.

Choose the subscription for the workflow

LinkedIn positions Core for individuals, Advanced for teams and Advanced Plus for teams needing deeper CRM integrations. Compare the current features before purchasing. Trial eligibility varies; do not base your operating plan on an assumed free trial. [1]

For a solo researcher, the important question is whether you can perform the required searches, save targets and manage your conversations. For a team, assess collaboration and seat management. For CRM-dependent operations, confirm the supported integration and the exact edition required. Keeping a spreadsheet alongside Core is a different workflow from native CRM synchronisation.

Set up the operating environment

Prepare a mandate brief, a company research register, a lead register, an approved messaging library and a meeting calendar. Decide which system is authoritative. Sales Navigator can hold research lists; the CRM or working register should hold stage, ownership and next action. Avoid keeping four competing versions of the same pipeline.

Use individual accounts and properly assigned seats where applicable. Do not give a service provider your password or verification codes. LinkedIn's agreement requires keeping passwords confidential and prohibits account sharing. A provider can support research, drafting and reporting while the authorised account holder sends messages. [2]

Agree working hours, response expectations and escalation routes with your team. These are coordination decisions, not reasons to share an identity. Use your scheduling and CRM tools' permission features for access to those systems.

Before the first campaign

Check that your profile, website and message tell the same story. Open the booking link on a second device. Confirm the intended host, calendar and time zone. Prepare a truthful answer to: Who are you representing? Why this company? What is the purpose of the meeting? Who will attend? What happens next?

If those questions are difficult to answer, pause outreach and improve the setup. A well-written message cannot repair an unclear proposition.

CHAPTER 03

Find the companies first

Research the business before the person.

A thousand names in a spreadsheet can look impressive. So can a yacht you do not own.

03

03 | Find the companies first

Accounts and leads answer different questions

In Sales Navigator, an account is a company and a lead is a person. An account search helps build the company universe. A lead search helps identify relevant people. For acquisition research, start with accounts when company characteristics drive the mandate; use leads when the mandate or known network makes a people-first approach sensible.

LinkedIn's search interface provides separate account and lead filters, with results updating as you refine them. Labels and availability change. Follow the current account and lead search controls rather than an old screenshot. [3]

Construct the first account search

Open the account filters. Set the intended headquarters geography, select a relevant industry and add the agreed headcount band. Apply other available criteria only where they help the mandate. Review a sample of results before introducing more restrictions.

Use keywords to describe what companies do. An industry category may combine several business models. For example, a broad logistics category may contain freight forwarders, delivery operators, software providers and warehouse businesses. Test terms such as **"last mile"**, **"air freight"** or **"contract logistics"** in separate searches and inspect the businesses returned.

The platform offers account filters including industry, headquarters location, company headcount and annual revenue. Treat them as screening tools. [4] When a desired attribute is unavailable, research it separately and mark its source. Do not invent a filter or pretend that a keyword proves an attribute.

Narrow a search without losing the market

Use one meaningful segment at a time: one sector, one region or one headcount band. This makes it easier to inspect results and compare quality. Splitting a broad search into small batches also exposes which criteria cause relevant businesses to disappear.

A large result count is not a quality standard. Choose segments your team can verify. Different mandates require different batch sizes; respond to the limits shown in your current interface rather than treating a past campaign target as a universal rule.

Headquarters is not the operating footprint

A company headquartered in London may serve customers across the UK. A regional branch may belong to a large international group. If the mandate requires a local operating business, check its offices, service area, website and corporate structure. Likewise, a person's profile geography may be different from the company's headquarters.

For US searches, state and regional segments can help organise work. Use the geographic options that your current interface actually provides. County or postcode information can remain useful in your research register even when it is not available as a search filter.

Save the reasoning

Record the search name, date, filters, keyword expression and reviewer. A useful name is **UK | Facilities services | 11-50 | v1**. Record why you added each restriction. If the search produces poor results, this log gives you something to change deliberately.

Before saving a company as qualified, inspect its website and description. Confirm that it sells the service you intend to buy and is not merely a similarly named organisation. Save interesting but uncertain companies into a review list, not the approved outreach list.

Use growth and company age as research hypotheses

An earlier US campaign separated companies by headcount-growth bands of 1%-10% and -10%-0%, then checked established-company status. You can adapt that segmentation where the relevant growth filter is available. Record exactly what the platform measures: employee growth is not revenue growth or profitability. A shrinking headcount can reflect restructuring, outsourcing or incomplete profile data.

That campaign also used a founding-year cutoff of 2015. A fixed year belongs to a specific brief and period. If your mandate requires ten years of trading, use a dated age criterion and verify it externally. Incorporation date, trading history and the owner's tenure are different facts. An owner's long tenure alone does not prove the company's age.

CHAPTER 04

Identify the right people and use Boolean search

Find the person who can move the conversation.

A title opens a research question. It does not settle ownership.

04

04 | Identify the right people and use Boolean search

A senior title is a clue, not proof of ownership

For an owner-led acquisition search, begin with people whose roles suggest responsibility for the business: owner, co-owner, founder, co-founder, managing director, CEO or managing partner. Confirm they currently work at the right company. A founder may have sold their shares; a CEO may be an employee; a director may lead a department.

The correct contact depends on the mandate. An owner may be best for a small business acquisition. A corporate development director may be appropriate when approaching a strategic buyer. A finance leader may help route a merger discussion. Do not turn a campaign's title exclusions into a rule for every transaction.

Use Boolean expressions for a specific question

LinkedIn supports uppercase **AND**, **OR** and **NOT**, straight quotation marks for phrases, and parentheses for grouped logic. Boolean search is supported in Company, title and keyword fields in Sales Navigator. Avoid wildcards and smart quotation marks. [5]

Use short expressions you can inspect. The examples below are original starting points, not guaranteed matches. Put title expressions in the relevant title field and service expressions in a keyword field, then check the results.

Owner-focused title search
(Owner OR Founder OR "Co-Founder" OR "Managing Director")

Executive title search
(CEO OR "Chief Executive Officer" OR President)

Strategic buyer contact search
("Corporate Development" OR "Mergers and Acquisitions" OR "M&A")

Service keyword search
("facilities management" OR "building maintenance")

Focused exclusion to test
(Owner OR Founder) NOT "Franchise Owner"

An exclusion can remove good prospects as well as bad ones. A franchise owner might be entirely suitable for one mandate and unsuitable for another. Check a sample before keeping an exclusion.

Map one primary contact, then a route in

Start with one primary person per company to avoid several uncoordinated approaches. Record an alternate contact or introducer when useful. Look for a genuine mutual connection, prior colleague or relevant professional relationship. Ask an introducer whether an introduction would be appropriate; do not imply endorsement merely because a connection appears on screen.

When there are several founders, note the uncertainty. The first contact may be able to explain how decisions are made. Your first message need not resolve the entire shareholder structure, but your research record should not label one person the sole owner without evidence.

Complete the contact record

Record the person's name, exact current title, company, ordinary LinkedIn profile URL, evidence date and contact status. A public profile URL normally uses **linkedin.com/in/**. Keep the Sales Navigator link separately if useful for your research. Check that the link opens the correct person.

If no Connect option is available, do not discard a suitable company automatically. An appropriate warm introduction or InMail may provide a route. Choose the channel based on relevance and availability, not a demand to contact every record.

CHAPTER 05

Qualify the list before anyone sends a message

Approve the evidence before the outreach.

A longer list is an easy achievement. A better list takes judgment.

05

05 | Qualify the list before anyone sends a message

Separate fit, evidence and timing

A lead can fit the mandate without being ready to transact. A company can appear attractive while important facts remain unknown. Record those distinctions. Research qualification means that a company deserves consideration under the mandate. Transaction qualification requires a conversation and further evidence.

Use three working lists: **Initial**, **Qualified** and **Rejected**, dated and named by campaign. Add a **Review** status for uncertain cases so that missing information does not disappear into a yes/no decision. Keep rejected records with a short reason to prevent repeated research.

A qualification rubric

Test	What to record	Decision
Business model	Website evidence of products, services and customers	Fits, exception or reject
Geography	Headquarters and actual operating area	Confirm fit or investigate
Scale	Headcount band and any sourced size indication	Indicative; financials later
Structure	Company identity, group links and ownership clues	Verify uncertainties
Contact	Current role and connection to the right company	Approve or find alternate
Exclusions	Any hard conflict with the mandate	Reject or principal review

Do not confuse employees visible on LinkedIn with a verified payroll count. Do not convert a platform revenue indication into a confirmed financial figure. Store the date and source beside the estimate. A research note should make uncertainty easy to see.

Review the first 50

The first 50 is a useful operating convention from the source material, not a required platform feature. A smaller mandate may justify 20. A complex mandate may need a smaller pilot followed by another review. The purpose is alignment before the campaign builds momentum.

Give the principal a list with reasons for inclusion and any uncertainties. Ask them to approve, reject or request changes. Record who approved the batch, when and under which mandate version. Replace rejected entries only after understanding why they failed. If several failures share a cause, fix the search rather than simply replacing names.

An independent reviewer can check the list against the brief before client review. This is particularly useful when sales, research and campaign delivery are performed by different people. Approval should refer to the actual criteria, not a general statement that the list looks fine.

Worked qualification example

Fictional company: Northbridge Building Services. Its website describes repeat commercial maintenance contracts in northern England. Sales Navigator places it in a suitable headcount band. The managing director appears to have a long association with the company. The website names the same person as founder.

The record can state: business-model fit confirmed from the website; geography appears suitable; scale indicative; ownership and profitability unverified; primary contact plausible. It cannot state: motivated seller, profitable acquisition, vendor finance available or deal-ready. Those are questions for a later conversation.

Clean the data

Check duplicates using company domain, company identity and profile URL. Two people at one company are not two target companies. Different trading names may belong to one group. Use explicit status fields rather than colour or bold formatting alone. Always preserve a rejection reason and a suppression record when someone asks not to be contacted.

CHAPTER 06

Save searches, watch alerts and choose the moment

Watch the signals. Verify the meaning.

An alert is a reason to look closer, not a reason to assume a sale.

06

06 | Save searches, watch alerts and choose the moment

A saved search is a reusable rule

Save a search after the sample results make sense. Saved searches preserve criteria and can notify you when new leads or accounts match. LinkedIn describes weekly email updates and homepage alerts for new matches. [6]

Keep a simple search register: name, mandate version, owner, creation date, last review, criteria and observations. When you change a material requirement, save a new version or document the revision. Otherwise you cannot tell whether better results came from better execution or a different target market.

A saved lead or account is a relationship to monitor

Saving a company or person is different from saving a search. The search finds new matches; the saved target lets you follow updates about an existing prospect. LinkedIn alerts can include company news, leadership changes and growth-related developments. [7]

Use these developments to prepare relevant questions. A leadership change may suggest a new decision-maker. A new office may support a discussion about geographic growth. A reported merger may explain why your old target is no longer independent. Verify the underlying event before acting on it.

Do not infer a sale from a signal

Hiring, slowing headcount growth and fresh funding can each have several explanations. They do not establish distress, cash flow or willingness to sell. A person using words such as exit, capital or private equity may be an adviser or investor rather than an owner considering a transaction.

Similarly, Buyer Intent relates to interest in products, services or a product category. It is not a measure of a shareholder's willingness to sell their company. Treat that distinction seriously when using sales-oriented tools for M&A research. [8]

Build a weekly monitoring routine

Review saved searches for new candidates. Review saved targets for changes that affect fit or contact choice. Check prospects whose agreed follow-up date has arrived. Move outdated records into review and correct roles that have changed.

Use a short research note: **What changed? What evidence supports it? Does it change the mandate fit? Does it justify contact now?** If the answer to the last question is no, retain the information without manufacturing a reason to send another message.

Prioritise with judgment

A simple internal priority scale is enough: **A** for strong fit with a clear contact route, **B** for good fit with evidence gaps, and **C** for a longer-term relationship. Keep readiness separate: interested now, later by agreement, unknown or declined. Priority should help allocate research time; it should not be presented as a scientific probability of closing.

The best timing often comes from something the owner actually said. If they ask you to reconnect after their year-end, record the date and the reason. That is stronger evidence than a broad activity signal.

CHAPTER 07

Start a conversation that makes sense

Give the owner a reason to respond.

I would love to connect is not an acquisition strategy, however expensive your subscription.

07

07 | Start a conversation that makes sense

Explain the reason for contact

An owner should be able to understand your message without opening a pitch deck. Identify your role, explain the connection to their business and make a modest request. Use one verified detail. A service line, market or region is more useful than a flattering sentence that could be sent to anyone.

Original templates follow. Replace bracketed details and use only statements you can substantiate. An opening message should not imply a concluded valuation, available funding or knowledge of confidential circumstances.

Connection request: business buyer

> Hello [First name], I'm researching established [sector] businesses in [region] as part of an acquisition search. [Company]'s work in [verified service] caught my attention. I'd welcome connecting. Godfred / [Your name]

After the connection is accepted

> Thank you for connecting, [First name]. I'm looking for an owner-led [sector] business where my background in [relevant experience] could support the next stage. I realise a transaction may not be on your agenda. Would you be open to a brief introductory conversation about [Company] and your plans for it?

InMail: a direct introduction

> **Subject: Introduction regarding [Company]**
> Hello [First name], I'm [role] focused on [specific market]. I found [Company] while researching [verified activity]. I'd value a short conversation to understand the business and whether a future ownership discussion could be relevant. If the timing is unsuitable, please let me know. [Name and credible contact link]

Follow-up with a purpose

> Hello [First name], following up on my introduction regarding [Company]. My interest is specifically in [relevant business characteristic]. If a short conversation would be useful, I can offer [two time options with time zone]. If it is not relevant, I will close the enquiry.

Closing the unanswered enquiry

> I'll leave the enquiry here, [First name]. If your plans change and an introduction becomes useful, you're welcome to reach me at [contact]. Thank you for considering it.

Set a reasonable sequence

A suggested pilot sequence is an introduction, one follow-up roughly a week later and a final note after a further interval. This is an editorial operating suggestion, not a LinkedIn rule or performance guarantee. Adjust to context. Stop when the person declines or asks not to be contacted. Do not schedule messages to someone who has already replied as if they were still silent.

LinkedIn applies invitation restrictions to members, including paid members. Watch the account's actual notifications rather than relying on a fixed weekly number from older campaign material. A restriction is a reason to stop sending invitations and follow the platform's guidance. [9]

Review every message before sending. Check the name, company, role, spelling and reason for contact. Avoid attachments or a long questionnaire in the first approach. The first objective is permission for a conversation, not a complete acquisition assessment.

CHAPTER 08

Handle replies without losing the relationship

Handle the answer with the same care as the approach.

A refusal handled well can preserve a relationship. Pressure rarely improves it.

08

08 | Handle replies without losing the relationship

Classify the response before answering

Use a small number of reply states: interested, information requested, later, referral, declined or outside scope. A reply is not necessarily an opportunity. The next action should reflect what the person actually said.

Interested

> Thank you, [First name]. A short introductory call would be a useful start. We can discuss the business, your priorities and whether there is a reason to continue. Would [option one] or [option two], [time zone], work? Alternatively, here is my booking link: [link].

Asking who you represent

> I'm approaching you as [accurate role]. The current brief is [short description]. [Principal's name or agreed public description] would attend the call. I can share [appropriate public information] beforehand so you can decide whether the discussion is relevant.

If you cannot name a confidential principal, explain the limitation honestly and offer what can be disclosed. Do not use confidentiality as a substitute for a credible identity.

Not considering a sale

> Understood, [First name]. Thank you for clarifying. I will close this acquisition enquiry. If you would prefer no further contact, I will record that as well.

If they independently express interest in a partnership rather than a sale, consider whether that fits your mandate. Do not treat a declined sale as permission for a new pitch.

Later, by agreement

> Thank you. Would it be appropriate to reconnect in [month], once [their stated event] has passed? I'll make a note of your preference.

Asking about price or financing

> It would be premature for me to give a valuation without understanding the business and the relevant information. A first call can establish fit and priorities. If there is mutual interest, we can agree the information needed for a more substantive discussion.

Do not promise an all-cash acquisition, vendor finance, a particular multiple or a timetable that the principal has not approved. An owner's age or career stage does not tell you which structure they will accept. Ask about their objectives instead of assigning a motive.

A question the research team cannot answer

Escalate to the principal with the exact question, the conversation context and a proposed reply. Once approved, add the response to the campaign FAQ. Note which parts are reusable and which apply only to that prospect. This preserves continuity without letting the delivery team improvise commitments.

Build the approved FAQ

Cover identity, mandate, attending principal, process, confidentiality, expected call length and information sharing. Have the principal approve anything relating to financing, fees, transaction terms or authority. Set a response target your team can meet and tell the client how urgent questions are escalated.

Record the substance of the exchange, not just a label such as warm. A useful note reads: **Owner open to discussing succession; wants existing staff retained; requests a call next Thursday.** Mark uncertain statements as reported by the owner until verified.

CHAPTER 09

Book the meeting and make the first call useful

Make the meeting worth accepting.

A full calendar is not a deal pipeline. Sometimes it is simply a scheduling problem.

09

09 | Book the meeting and make the first call useful

Remove friction from scheduling

Offer two times with an explicit time zone or provide a tested booking link. A booking page should show the correct host, duration, availability and meeting method. Connect the relevant calendar to reduce double-booking and configure the video-conference link where supported. Calendly's official guidance is linked at the back. [10]

Decide who owns rescheduling and no-shows. Record the appointment as booked, attended, cancelled, rescheduled or no-show. Counting every booking as an attended meeting hides an important part of campaign quality.

For a team, a shared booking link may use a round-robin or collective-host arrangement, depending on the tools and subscription. Make sure the prospect knows who will actually attend. Allocation should reflect deal responsibility and expertise rather than simply the next available slot.

Send a short confirmation

> Thank you, [First name]. Our introductory call is booked for [date], [time] [time zone], with [attendee]. The invitation includes the meeting link. We will discuss [Company], your priorities and whether a further conversation would be useful. Please let me know if you need to reschedule.

Keep the agenda modest. A 20-30 minute introduction can cover the reason for contact, the owner's account of the business and an agreed next step. Avoid implying that the meeting is an offer or a commitment to proceed.

Prepare before the call

Read the company website, the research record and the entire conversation. Confirm names and roles. Note three things you understand and three things you need to clarify. Check the principal's capacity and mandate so the discussion does not stray into promises they cannot keep.

Listen for the owner's actual objective

An opening question could be: **How did the business develop, and what would you like its next few years to look like?** Let the owner explain. Follow up on their priorities: growth, succession, time, management capacity, capital or the future of their staff.

Ask rather than infer. Someone may want investment while retaining control. Someone else may want a complete exit but care deeply about the company's name. A merger

discussion may be about distribution or capability rather than liquidity. Repeat your understanding and ask whether you have it right.

Agree the next step

Close with a specific action: another meeting, an introduction to a co-owner, an agreed information exchange or a later reconnection. If confidentiality is necessary before information is shared, agree the NDA process and who is responsible for it. An NDA should fit the transaction and parties; a generic example is not an automatic fit.

Write the call note immediately: participants, stated objectives, open questions, agreed action, owner and date. Distinguish an exploratory relationship from a qualified opportunity. If there is no fit, record the reason and close the active enquiry cleanly.

CHAPTER 10

Build a pipeline you can trust

Know what is real, what is pending and what comes next.

If nobody owns the next action, the pipeline owns you.

10

10 | Build a pipeline you can trust

Research and transactions need different stages

A research list records possible targets. A transaction pipeline records an actual process. Keep them linked, but do not move every accepted connection into a deal stage. Use evidence-based entry rules.

Stage	Entry condition	Next-action example
Qualified for outreach	Public evidence fits approved brief	Principal approves introduction
Contacted	Actual outreach sent	Review reply or follow-up date
Conversation active	Substantive exchange underway	Answer question or offer call
Meeting booked	Time and attendees confirmed	Prepare and confirm
First meeting completed	Meeting actually took place	Record fit and next step
Further review agreed	Both parties agree to continue	NDA or information request
Transaction process	Formal assessment underway	Deal team owns process
Nurture / closed	Agreed later date or no active process	Reconnect by agreement or stop

Track the later process separately

The source material includes NDA sent and signed, financials collected, valuation, deal structure, further meetings, offer, negotiation, heads of terms, due diligence, financing, legal work, closed won and closed lost. These are useful tracking labels, not a mandatory legal sequence. Transactions vary and several activities may run together.

Assign a responsible person and completion evidence to each later stage. A signed document, an agreed meeting or an information receipt is more useful than a researcher

deciding that a prospect feels ready. Keep follow-up as a next action rather than an all-purpose stage that obscures what has happened.

Minimum records

Keep company name, domain, company identity where known, sector, location, contact name, title, profile link, research source, mandate version, campaign owner, outreach date, reply category, next action, due date, appointment status and relevant notes. Record email or telephone details only where appropriately obtained and needed.

Use access controls for sensitive information. Do not put confidential financials in a broadly shared prospect sheet. Keep a clear distinction between public research and the information exchanged during a transaction process.

Report outcomes, not just activity

Daily delivery updates can state what was researched, which questions need principal input and which meetings require attention. The weekly report should show qualified targets, actual outreach, accepted invitations, substantive replies, booked and attended meetings, further reviews agreed and the main reasons for rejection.

Define every metric. An appointment is a booking; an attended meeting is a completed call. A qualified opportunity is a case that satisfies your documented criteria after discussion. Avoid using pipeline to mean both unanswered messages and genuine transaction opportunities.

A fictional funnel calculation

Suppose a pilot sends 80 invitations, receives 24 acceptances, messages all 24 and receives 8 substantive replies. Five meetings are booked, four take place and two lead to further review. Invitation acceptance is 24/80 = 30%. Substantive replies are 8/24 = 33.3% of messaged connections. Meeting attendance is 4/5 = 80%.

These figures are an arithmetic illustration, not a benchmark. Compare cohorts over consistent observation periods. Recent invitations have had less time to convert; rescheduled meetings should not be counted twice. Preserve the denominators so a client can understand what each percentage means.

CHAPTER 11

Adapt the method for sellers and merger partners

Change the search when the mandate changes.

Buying, selling and combining businesses deserve different conversations.

11

11 | Adapt the method for sellers and merger partners

Sell-side research starts with the asset

A seller's adviser needs a buyer universe suited to the business being sold. Begin with a clear description of the asset, the mandate, what may be disclosed and the owner's priorities. Identify strategic buyers, relevant investment firms and other permitted buyer categories separately. Do not send a buyer-style acquisition message to someone you hope will acquire your client's business.

For strategic buyers, research companies with a plausible reason to own the asset: adjacent geography, complementary services, useful capability or a stated acquisition strategy. Verify public announcements and portfolio information independently. Similarity alone does not prove appetite, funding or approval authority.

For financial buyers, examine investment focus, geography, scale and portfolio context on their own websites. Sales Navigator helps identify relevant professionals; the firm's published criteria and a conversation help establish whether the mandate fits. A person with private equity in their profile is not necessarily the person who reviews your type of opportunity.

A discreet sell-side introduction

> Hello [First name], I advise [accurate description of role] and am assessing potential buyers for an established [sector] business in [broad region]. Its [permitted characteristic] may be relevant to [Buyer]'s activity in [verified area]. Would the right person on your team be open to an initial discussion? I can share the agreed non-confidential summary first.

Use only information approved for disclosure. Even a short description can identify a company in a narrow market. Record which materials were sent to which recipient. If a principal requires an NDA before more detail, follow that sequence.

Merger research needs a strategic hypothesis

Write down what the combination might achieve: broader distribution, an additional technical capability, regional coverage or a complementary customer base. Then record the assumptions that need testing. Do not describe an imagined synergy as a proven result.

Map the people who can sponsor and assess the discussion. In a founder-led company this may be the owner. In a larger group it may include corporate development, finance and the relevant operating leader. The first contact's job is to open or route the conversation; they may not have authority to approve a transaction.

A merger or combination introduction

> Hello [First name], I'm [accurate role] at [organisation]. We are exploring whether a combination with a business offering [capability] could make strategic sense. [Company]'s work in [verified area] is relevant to that review. Would a confidential introductory discussion be appropriate, or is there someone else who should assess it?

Keep the boundaries clear

Maintain separate lists, messaging and qualification rules for acquisition targets, prospective buyers and merger partners. Confirm representation, confidentiality and authority before outreach. Stop when the mandate changes until the principal approves a revised approach. The same research discipline can serve all three workflows, but the proposition and decision-makers must match the transaction.

CHAPTER 12

Run the operation without losing control

Give the operation a clear owner.

Everyone wants an off-market deal. Remarkably few want to do the off-market work.

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12 | Run the operation without losing control

Make responsibilities explicit

In a small team, one person may do several jobs. The responsibilities still need to be clear. The principal owns the mandate and substantive transaction decisions. The researcher owns evidence and list quality. The campaign coordinator owns the queue, message checks and follow-up records. The meeting owner owns the first call and handover.

If you provide origination support to a client, agree what the service includes: research, qualification, message drafting, authorised outreach arrangements, reply coordination, appointment administration and reporting. State who takes calls and manages the relationship afterwards. Do not let a meeting-booking service imply responsibility for closing a transaction.

Build the campaign record

Whether you use Trello, a CRM or a structured register, every campaign should have the brief, current filters, approved messages, principal contact, calendar link, batch approvals, FAQ, research register and reporting schedule. Keep the latest version in one place and link to it from other tools.

Use a daily queue for replies awaiting approval, meetings needing action, overdue follow-ups and research questions. Review urgent items first. At the end of the day, confirm that every active conversation has an owner and a next action. A large number of open tabs is not a control system.

Manage changes and complaints with evidence

If a client rejects an appointment from an approved list, compare the actual company and person against the agreed criteria. A genuine research error should be corrected. A new preference should be documented as a mandate change. Approval of a list never removes the need to handle quality concerns seriously.

Avoid overpromising during sales conversations. Agree the definition of a qualified introduction, what counts as a booking, how no-shows are handled and what reporting will show. Historical campaign guarantees or appointment totals should not become promises of completed acquisitions. A meeting can be useful without becoming a deal.

Diagnose the point of failure

Observation	Examine first	Possible action
Many unsuitable companies	Mandate, industry and keywords	Refine one research segment
Right firms, wrong people	Role checks and contact mapping	Rebuild the contact sample
Few accepted invitations	Profile, relevance and route in	Improve credibility; test introductions
Connections, few replies	Reason for contact and proposition	Rewrite the opening with specific context
Replies, few bookings	Principal response and scheduling	Resolve unanswered questions; test link
Meetings, little further interest	Actual fit and first-call notes	Revisit assumptions and criteria

These are diagnostic prompts, not automatic explanations. Look at actual conversations before changing a campaign. A small sample can mislead.

Test carefully

Compare one change at a time, such as two openings within the same suitable segment. Keep dates and cohorts comparable and measure substantive replies and fit, not just acceptance. Do not send competing tests to the same person. Explain changes to the principal and retain the original version so the result can be interpreted.

CHAPTER 13

Your first 30 days

Start deliberately. Measure honestly.

Thirty days of disciplined work will tell you more than thirty days of enthusiasm.

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13 | Your first 30 days

Days 1-5: establish the foundation

Write and approve the mandate. Complete the profile review. Choose the subscription and operating tools. Prepare the registers, calendar and original message drafts. Define the team roles and escalation route. Success at this stage means a clear setup, not outreach volume.

Build two or three research segments. Inspect sample companies from each and note recurring mismatches. Check how the companies describe themselves on their websites. Save searches only after the results appear relevant.

Days 6-10: review the first batch

Research a pilot batch appropriate to the mandate. Apply the qualification rubric, record evidence gaps and check duplicates. Identify one primary contact per company. Have a second person review difficult cases if available. Present the first batch to the principal with clear inclusion reasons.

Record approval and changes. Revise the filters when the review reveals a recurring problem. Test the booking flow with a colleague and verify the confirmation, host, calendar and meeting link. Review the FAQ before sending the first introduction.

Days 11-20: run a controlled pilot

Send individually reviewed introductions through the authorised account holder. Work within the restrictions shown by LinkedIn. Record actual contact dates. Check replies regularly and respond in context. Escalate questions that go beyond the approved scope.

Use daily updates to identify blockers. Prepare each meeting properly and record attendance and outcomes. Do not judge the entire search by a few early replies, and do not describe a new campaign's timing as a guaranteed path to meetings.

Days 21-30: learn and decide

Review the funnel by cohort. Examine rejected targets and actual conversations. Identify the weakest step and choose one change to test. Check whether attended meetings are producing useful next steps. Revisit the mandate if the underlying business fit is wrong.

Decide whether to continue, revise a segment, pause for principal capacity or close an unsuitable campaign. Scale only when research quality, replies and meeting handover can be maintained. Expansion should include clear ownership and reporting, not simply a larger weekly invitation target.

The end-of-month review

Ask: Can we explain why each target fits? Are the contact roles verified? Is the proposition clear? Are difficult questions answered by the right person? Can we distinguish booked meetings from attended meetings? Is every active opportunity assigned? Have declines and contact preferences been respected?

A sound origination process survives scrutiny. If another professional can open the record and understand the company, evidence, conversation and next step, the system is doing its job. Continue to improve those records as the relationship moves toward a transaction.

Appendix A | The working forms

1. Mandate brief

Use: Complete before research and approve each material revision.

Field	Your answer
Principal and approved representative	_____
Transaction objective	_____
Sector and business model	_____
Geography: HQ, operations or customers	_____
Size: indication now, evidence later	_____
Ownership preferences	_____
Firm exclusions	_____
Acceptable exceptions	_____
Public description and approved disclosure	_____
Mandate version, approver and date	_____

2. Company and contact record

Use: One company record, linked to each relevant person.

Company name and domain: _____

Company identity / group relationship: _____

Business-model evidence and source date: _____

Location and scale indications: _____

Primary contact, exact title and profile URL: _____

Ownership evidence / uncertainty: _____

Mandate fit, exception and rejection reason: _____

Researcher, reviewer and batch version: _____

Status, record owner, next action and date: _____

3. First-batch approval

Use: Document alignment before outreach.

Batch name and number of records: _____

Mandate version checked: _____

Approved records / rejected records / pending review: _____

Recurring mismatch and agreed correction: _____

Approved message version: _____

Principal approval and date: _____

4. First-call note

Use: Complete immediately after the conversation.

Company, attendees and date: _____

Owner's stated objectives, in their meaning: _____

Business facts discussed / verification outstanding: _____

Decision-makers still to involve: _____

Confidentiality or information-sharing arrangements: _____

Fit assessment and reason: _____

Agreed action, responsible person and due date: _____

5. Weekly review

Use: Report one consistent period and identify the action required.

Metric	Count / explanation
Companies reviewed and qualified	_____
Invitations and direct introductions sent	_____
Acceptances and substantive replies	_____
Meetings booked / attended / rescheduled	_____
Further reviews mutually agreed	_____
Rejections and leading reasons	_____
Replies awaiting principal input	_____
One recommended change	_____

Include the campaign version, reporting period and definitions. Keep activity totals separate from rates. State the denominator and observation period whenever you report a percentage.

Appendix B | Search recipes and quality checks

Three research recipes

All companies and scenarios below are fictional. The criteria are examples to adapt, not investment recommendations.

Regional acquisition search. Filter accounts by agreed geography, service industry and one size band. Check websites for business-model fit. Identify an owner or managing director within approved accounts. Verify company identity; mark financial information as unknown until obtained.

Strategic buyer search. Map adjacent operators and verify their public acquisition strategy. Search suitable accounts for **"Corporate Development" OR "M&A"** contacts. Confirm responsibility before sharing an approved mandate summary.

Merger-partner search. Define the missing capability or market. Find relevant companies and review leadership and group structure. Identify an operating sponsor and transaction contact. Prepare a specific strategic question.

Pre-send quality check

1. The company fits the current mandate or has an approved exception.
2. The person currently belongs to the correct company.
3. The message describes the sender's role accurately.
4. The personalisation comes from a verified source.
5. The name, company and all placeholders have been checked.
6. The recipient has not declined or requested no further contact.
7. The next action and record owner are clear.

Meeting handover check

1. Date, time zone, host and meeting method are confirmed.
2. The principal has read the research and conversation history.
3. The prospect understands the purpose of the introduction.
4. Sensitive information has an agreed sharing process.
5. Attendance and the agreed next step will be recorded.

Appendix C | Terms used in this book

Account: A company record in Sales Navigator.

Lead: A person record in Sales Navigator. It does not automatically mean a qualified transaction opportunity.

Mandate: The approved objective, criteria, authority and scope of a search or advisory assignment.

Origination: Finding and developing the relationships from which a transaction opportunity may emerge.

Research-qualified target: A company that fits the approved public-data screening criteria, subject to recorded uncertainties.

Qualified opportunity: A case that meets your documented criteria after substantive discussion and has a mutually agreed next step.

Nurture: A relationship with an agreed future contact date or a clear reason for continued monitoring.

NDA: A non-disclosure agreement used to govern an agreed confidential information exchange.

Heads of terms / letter of intent: Documents recording proposed transaction terms. Their effect depends on wording and jurisdiction; they should not be treated as interchangeable standard forms.

Due diligence: The deeper assessment performed in a transaction process. Public LinkedIn research is not a substitute.

CRM: The system used to record contacts, conversations, responsibilities and stages.

Cohort: A group first contacted within the same defined period, used to compare results more fairly.

References | Official resources and editorial basis

LinkedIn resources

These links support the platform-specific passages marked [1]-[9]. Reviewed for this edition on 12 October 2026. Product labels, access and subscription details may change.

[1] **Sales Navigator plans and features.** Official comparison page for Core, Advanced and Advanced Plus, including trial information.

https://business.linkedin.com/sell/sales-navigator/compare-plans

[2] **LinkedIn User Agreement.** Account security, account-sharing terms and permitted use.

https://www.linkedin.com/legal/user-agreement

[3] **Search in Sales Navigator.** Current search interface, lead/account distinction and changes to filter labels.

https://www.linkedin.com/help/sales-navigator/answer/a106027

[4] **Advanced Search Filters.** Official overview of people and company search attributes.

https://business.linkedin.com/sell/sales-navigator/advanced-search-filters

[5] **Using Boolean Search on Sales Navigator.** Operators, quotation marks and supported fields.

https://www.linkedin.com/help/sales-navigator/answer/a168061

[6] **Save lead and account searches.** Saving criteria and receiving updates about new matches.

https://www.linkedin.com/help/sales-navigator/answer/a102024

[7] **Sales Navigator alerts.** Updates associated with saved leads and accounts.

https://www.linkedin.com/help/sales-navigator/answer/a105133

[8] **Sales Navigator Buyer Intent FAQ.** Meaning and application of product-oriented intent signals.

https://www.linkedin.com/help/sales-navigator/answer/a507435

[9] **Invitation limits and restrictions.** Official guidance on restricted invitation sending.

https://www.linkedin.com/help/sales-navigator/answer/a550555/invitation-limit-reached?lang=en

https://www.linkedin.com/help/sales-navigator/answer/a551012

Scheduling and research resources

[10] **Calendly Help Center.** Calendar connections, conferencing, event types and team scheduling. Verify the features available on your plan.

https://help.calendly.com/

https://calendly.com/help/calendly-zoom

https://calendly.com/help/integrations-faq

Companies House: UK company identity and filing research.

https://find-and-update.company-information.service.gov.uk/

Endole: Additional UK company research. Confirm the source and date of any data used.

https://www.endole.co.uk/

Editorial basis

The operational foundation includes the author's working material titled New lead filtering process; Onboarding Process for a New Client; Templates for client response; Workflow Map for Campaign Management; Sales Navigator Outreach Instructions (Written); Get Leads; Business Growth Through Expert Lead Generation; and the Lead Gen data screenshot archive.

These materials informed the research, first-batch approval, reply coordination, scheduling and reporting methods. The book uses original explanations, fictional examples and new templates. Employer or third-party branding, private client records, old account-sharing instructions and historical commercial terms have not been republished as the author's offer. No historical appointment total or conversion claim is offered as a general result readers should expect.

About the author



Godfred Ofosu Asante works where B2B prospecting meets M&A deal origination: identifying the right companies, reaching decision-makers and turning research into substantive commercial conversations.

His experience spans work with founders, managing directors and senior executives across Europe, Asia and North America. He has overseen prospecting and appointment-setting delivery for more than 100 clients and booked over 1,000 appointments, supporting conversations around business acquisitions, mergers and growth opportunities.

That work has shaped a clear conviction: access is earned through preparation. A long prospect list means little without sound qualification, a credible approach and disciplined follow-through.

He is also the founder of Mad Buddy, bringing a builder's perspective to strategy and execution.

> **Know what you want. Know whom you're approaching. Make the conversation count.**

Work with Godfred

For prospect research, target-list review, outreach preparation or campaign oversight, send a short brief with your sector, geography, intended transaction, company size and current stage.

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